

The House on Briar Lane

A horror short story

Chapter One: The Move-In

Naila had walked through eleven houses before this one, and none of them felt wrong the way this one did. It wasn't anything she could point to. The paint was fresh, the floors didn't creak, the price was almost insultingly low for a four bedroom house two streets from the good school. Her husband Danish had already signed the papers by the time she mentioned the smell, faint and sweet, like flowers left too long in standing water, coming from somewhere behind the walls of the upstairs hallway.

The real estate agent had mentioned, almost as an afterthought while locking up after the final walkthrough, that the previous family had only lived there for four months before relisting. "Relocated for work," she said, not quite meeting Naila's eyes. Naila did not ask why a family would relocate for work and leave behind a fully furnished nursery, curtains still hanging, crib still assembled, as if they had walked out mid-afternoon and simply never come back for it.

They moved in on a Saturday. By Sunday night, Naila had already learned not to look too long at the space beneath the stairs, where the shadows seemed to sit differently than shadows should, thicker at the edges, reluctant to move even when she waved her hand through the light meant to disturb them.

Chapter Two: The Sound in the Walls

It began as a scratching, faint enough that Danish insisted it was rodents and set traps in the crawlspace without complaint. The traps stayed empty for a week. The scratching continued anyway, always at night, always tracing a slow path along the wall that ran behind their bed, as though something were dragging itself from one end of the house to the other, patient and unbothered by time.

Their daughter Amal, six years old and prone to elaborate imaginary friends, began describing a woman who sat at the foot of her bed and hummed until she fell asleep. Naila dismissed it the way she dismissed all of Amal's stories, until the night she woke at three in the morning to find her daughter's bedroom door open, the humming audible even from the hallway, stopping the instant Naila's foot touched the top stair.

She found Amal awake and calm, sitting up in bed, watching the corner of the room with the mild, unbothered attention of a child watching television. "She says the last family left because they were rude to her," Amal said, not looking away from the corner. "She says we shouldn't

make the same mistake."

Chapter Three: What Was Under the Stairs

Danish finally agreed to open the space beneath the stairs after three weeks of scratching, humming, and a growing unease that neither of them could name out loud without feeling foolish. The access panel had been painted shut, layer over layer, as though someone had wanted it sealed for good and simply run out of paint before running out of will.

Behind it, they found a narrow crawlspace holding nothing but a child's rocking chair, facing the wall, rocking very slightly though there was no draft to move it and no one had touched it in what looked like years. Beside the chair sat a small wooden box, and inside the box, a bundle of letters addressed to a name neither of them recognized, each one beginning the same way: I am so sorry we left you here, we will come back, we promise we will come back.

Naila closed the box without reading further. That night, for the first time since they had moved in, there was no scratching, no humming, no shifting of shadows beneath the stairs. Only a silence so complete it felt like something holding its breath, waiting to see whether this family, unlike all the ones before it, might finally be the one who kept its word.